

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 26

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Bugisu District, Mount Elgon region, Uganda

Section Title(S)

Ritual and other Ties between Lineages • THE KINSHIP SYSTEM • The Minimal Lineage

A minimal lineage has a depth of between three and five generations from the oldest living generation. Its members consider one another close kin and it is believed that the connection between any two members can be traced.

Members of a minimal lineage address one another by kinship terms; sexual intercourse with a lineage member is incest and pollutes the whole lineage, as does the killing of another member. In both cases purificatory sacrifices must be performed. The minimal lineage is jointly responsible for the acts of its members, and any member of the lineage of a malefactor may suffer retribution at the hands of the injured party. Members of lineages of wider span than the minimal lineage are not so closely identified, although they are kin (*balebi*) by virtue of their common lineage affiliation.

601
[Kinship Terminology](#)

613
[Lineages](#)

627
[Informal In-Group Justice](#)

682
[Offenses Against Life](#)

835
[Kinship Regulation Of Sex](#)

The lineage system grows and expands by the fission of minimal lineages. Each minimal lineage has internal divisions which may become the points of fission. Such divisions become relevant at the meeting to choose the heir to the status of a dead member; quarrels may arise over the distribution of the meat of the bull killed to end the mourning period. Periodic occurrences of "incest" between members of the same lineage may result in the recognition by elders of the lineage that the division endangers the unity of the minimal lineage. Jural recognition of the independence of the sections is given by the elders announcing that the rule of exogamy no longer applies to the whole minimal lineage. The new exogamic lineages then act as minimal lineages and in time the genealogy of the minor lineage is adjusted to legitimize the new situation.

428
[Inheritance](#)

578
[Ingroup Antagonisms](#)

613
[Lineages](#)

835
[Kinship Regulation Of Sex](#)

Ritual and other Ties between Lineages

These ties generally exist between minor lineages and may form the basis of alliances in war. A common tie between minor lineages is the use of a common shrine or sacred spot for the performance of ritual, either jointly or in succession. Ties of kinship or affinity between the founders of lineages also exist, together with ritual association or independently of it. Most of these ties are based on real or legendary marriages between members of the two lineages concerned.

613
Lineages

778
Sacred Objects And
Places

A special tie is that known as *bagulo* which involves two lineages in a joking relationship. Members of lineages who are *bagulo* joke with one another and may seize one another's property with impunity. This licence especially extends to young men who seize cows with which to pay bridewealth. The origin of the *bagulo* tie is given different explanations in different areas of Bugisu. It is said to have resulted either from a long-standing period of hostility which was ended in a solemn peace-pact; or, particularly in the south, to be a link deriving from a marriage some generations ago between founders or members of the two lineages. The marriage was far enough back in time for it to be no longer relevant in terms of marriage rules but near enough for the link to be remembered.

602
Kin Relationships

613
Lineages

Within a minor lineage each minimal lineage has ritual rights and duties towards the minor lineage as a whole. Some minimal lineages are linked together by the tradition that their founders had the same maternal origin which is distinct from the maternal origin of other minimal lineages of their minor lineage. The link may be expressed in marriage prohibitions or in common ritual activity.

613
Lineages

THE KINSHIP SYSTEM

The Gisu have a classificatory terminology. In general, terms of address and 27 terms of reference are the same. Relationships of super- and subordination are shown by the rules which govern the permitted use of given names in place of the kinship term and which set out the relatives who must be addressed by terms of respect. No one may address a relative or affine of the immediately senior generation by his or her personal name. In some cases the name must not even be mentioned by a junior kinsman. Senior kinsmen and affines must be addressed by a term of respect.

551
Personal Names

561
Age Stratification

601
Kinship Terminology

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